

assumptions about supposed Black inferiority. The same people who were committed to notions of equality before the law often did not believe in true social equality. Public newspaper reports increasingly highlighted corruption and chaos in Southern governments, depicting Black voters and politicians in unfavorable terms. The perennial Southern violence at election time seemed insurmountable. Judging the mood of the North, President Grant was hesitant to extend further federal power to keep the peace and enforce Black rights.

In 1875, came the largest blot on the President's scandal-prone record: the exposure of the "Whiskey Ring." Liquor taxes had been raised in the postwar years to help the government pay off the costs of the conflict. In response, a group, or "ring," of Midwestern distilleries bribed Federal agents to allow them to keep back most of the tax revenue. As a result, the Treasury was being defrauded of millions of dollars. Grant's own private secretary, Orville E. Babcock, a former Union general, was implicated, but the President shielded him by praising his character.